

UX CASE STUDY

Carvi Food

Senegal's First Dried Meat Brand Ever

From Product-Market Pioneer to Frictionless Digital Commerce

Founded: 2017

Industry: Food and FMCG — Dried Meat Production

Country: Senegal

UX Focus: Product-market fit - E-commerce - WhatsApp integration

Designer: Alimatou - UX Designer

Carvi Food: Pioneering a Product Category in Senegal

A story of market creation, consumer education, and building trust for a product that had no local precedent.

Company	Carvi Food
Founded	2017
Product	Dried meat (biltong-style) - produced locally in Senegal
Market	Senegal, West Africa (with diaspora reach)
UX Role	Founder-level UX: product design, brand, digital experience, e-commerce
Timeline	2017 – Present (ongoing)

01 - The Problem: A Market That Did Not Know It Was Waiting

The Gap

Before Carvi Food, no producer in Senegal offered locally manufactured dried meat. The product existed culturally (dried and smoked meat has deep roots in Senegalese cuisine) but never as a branded, packaged, commercially distributed product made in-country. Consumers had no reference point. There was no competitor. And no existing customer journey to map from.

This is one of the rarest UX challenges: designing the experience for a product that consumers have never encountered in this form before. There is no comparison point, no established expectation — and no existing trust.

The Core UX Challenges at Launch

- How do you create desire for a product no one has asked for — but everyone will recognize once they try it?
- How do you communicate quality, freshness, and safety for a food product in a market unfamiliar with the brand?
- How do you build a purchase journey when there is no established retail or distribution channel for this category?
- How do you build consumer trust fast enough to survive as a first mover?

02 - Research and Discovery

Understanding the Consumer Landscape

Even without formal UX tools at launch, Carvi Food's founding decisions were grounded in observation and hypothesis testing — the core of UX research:

Insight	Design Response
Dried meat has deep cultural resonance in Senegal	Position as authentic, modern, local — not foreign
Most consumers buy from informal markets with no quality guarantee	Create visible quality signals: packaging, labels, certifications
No local brand occupied the premium dried meat space	Build brand as the quality reference — own the category
The Senegalese diaspora craves authentic local products abroad	Design for diaspora gifting as a secondary market from day one

03 - Product-Market Fit as a UX Decision

Bringing Carvi Food to market was itself a UX design process. Key decisions included:

Packaging Design

Without visible packaging, dried meat reads as informal or unsafe. Carvi Food designed branded packaging that communicated cleanliness, artisanal care, and Senegalese identity. The package was the first touchpoint — and it had to do the work of an entire brand story.

Taste as a UX Deliverable

Product-market fit for a food brand starts with the product itself. Carvi Food iterated on recipes, spice profiles, and texture — gathering feedback from early customers and refining the product. Each iteration was equivalent to a usability test: does this meet user expectations? Does it delight?

Pricing and Accessibility

First-mover pricing required a balance: too cheap and the product would not be perceived as quality; too expensive and adoption would stall. The pricing strategy was designed around perceived value — anchoring Carvi Food as premium but accessible.

04 — Key Metrics (2017–2026)

9+ Years in market as category leader	80%+ Returning customers (active)	1st Locally made dried meat brand in Senegal
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05 — Outcome

Category Creation as UX Success

Carvi Food did not just launch a product — it created a new consumer category in Senegal. The brand became the reference point: when consumers think of locally made dried meat, they think Carvi Food. This is the deepest form of product-market fit — not competing in a category, but owning it. The UX lesson: when no competitor exists, your brand design IS the category design.

From Broken Checkout to Frictionless WhatsApp Commerce

How a failed e-commerce experience led to a platform redesign that matched real customer behavior.

Problem	Customers could not complete orders on the original website
Root Cause	Complex checkout flow misaligned with how 80%+ of customers communicate
Solution	New website with WhatsApp-integrated ordering — one click to message
Impact	Reduced order friction to near zero; orders now come in via WhatsApp daily
Tools Used	Website redesign, WhatsApp Business API, Customer behavior analysis

01 — The Problem: A Checkout That Lost Customers

What Was Happening

The original Carvi Food website had a product catalog and a checkout flow. In theory, customers could browse, select, and order. In practice, they didn't. Orders were not completing. Customers were visiting but not converting. The purchase journey had too much friction — and it was built on the wrong communication channel.

This is a classic UX failure pattern: a solution designed around what seemed logical, not around how real users actually behave.

02 — Research: Understanding the Real User Behavior

The WhatsApp Insight

A critical discovery emerged from talking to customers and observing how they placed orders before the website existed:

The Data Point That Changed Everything

Over 80% of Carvi Food customers — since the company's founding in 2017 — are active WhatsApp users. They were already messaging to ask about products, confirm availability, and place orders manually. WhatsApp was not an alternative to e-commerce. For this audience, WhatsApp IS e-commerce.

Old Assumption (Design)	Real User Behavior (Research)
Customers want a full e-commerce checkout	Customers want to confirm with a human before paying
Add to cart → Fill form → Submit → Wait for confirmation	Browse → Have a question → Message directly → Confirm → Pay
A website-native flow is the standard	WhatsApp is the primary commerce interface in Senegal
Phone number is for support, not primary orders	WhatsApp IS the phone number they trust

03 — The Redesign: Meeting Users Where They Are

Design Principles for the New Website

- Reduce steps to zero: the only goal of the website is to get the customer to a WhatsApp conversation in one tap
- Trust before transaction: show the product, price, and story — then remove all checkout friction
- Mobile-first, always: all Senegalese customers access on mobile; desktop is secondary
- WhatsApp as the CTA: every product page ends with a WhatsApp button pre-filled with the order message

The New Order Flow

Before (Broken Flow)	After (Redesigned Flow)
1. Visit website	1. Visit website
2. Browse products	2. Browse products with clear prices
3. Add to cart	3. Tap 'Order on WhatsApp'
4. Fill out checkout form	4. Pre-filled WhatsApp message opens
5. Submit order	5. Send - conversation begins instantly
6. Wait for email confirmation	—
7. Separately message on WhatsApp to confirm	—
Result: Most users drop off at step 4 or 5	Result: Order journey in 3 taps

WhatsApp Message Pre-fill Design

A key UX detail : the WhatsApp button was designed to pre-populate the message with the product name, quantity field, and a friendly opener. The customer only needs to tap Send. This reduced the cognitive load of ordering to near zero.

Example Pre-filled Message

Hello Carvi Food 🙋 I would like to order: • Product: [Dried Beef — Classic Spice] • Quantity: ____ •
Delivery address: ____ Please confirm availability and price. Thank you!

04 — UX Considerations: Accessibility and Context

The redesign was also informed by the specific digital context of the Senegalese market:

Constraint	Design Response
Low average mobile data speed in some areas	Lightweight website — images compressed, minimal JS
Users switch apps frequently — web sessions are short	Conversion goal is a single tap, not a full session
Limited trust in online payment forms	No credit card form — payment discussed directly on WhatsApp
Many users are first-time e-commerce users	Familiar interface (WhatsApp) removes learning curve entirely

05 — Outcome

3 Taps to complete an order (vs. 7+ steps before)	80%+ Customers on WhatsApp — now primary channel	↑ ↑ Order conversion after redesign
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The Core UX Lesson

The best digital experience is not always the most sophisticated one. For Carvi Food's audience, WhatsApp is the internet. A good UX designer meets users where they are — not where the designer expects them to be. Redesigning around WhatsApp was not a compromise. It was the correct user-centered decision.

Additional UX Dimensions: Brand, Trust and Retention

Beyond the website — how Carvi Food applied UX thinking across the full customer experience.

A — Brand Experience Design

Carvi Food's brand is a UX artifact. Every visual and verbal element was designed to communicate specific values to a specific audience:

Brand Signal	UX Translation
Local production (Made in Senegal)	Reduces purchase anxiety — no import uncertainty
Artisanal quality	Packaging language, craft narrative, texture/weight of packaging
Natural ingredients	Ingredient transparency — builds trust in food safety
Reliability and consistency	Same product every time — repeatability as a UX feature
Modern + rooted in culture	Visual identity that feels premium but locally familiar

B — Customer Retention as UX

With 80%+ of customers being active since 2017, Carvi Food has achieved strong retention — which is a direct UX outcome. Retention does not happen by accident; it is the result of consistent positive experience across every touchpoint:

- Product consistency: customers know exactly what they will receive — zero surprise (the best kind of UX)
- Personal WhatsApp relationship: each customer interacts with the brand directly, not through a faceless system
- Fast response time: WhatsApp enables near-instant replies — a key UX driver for repeat purchase
- Gifting use case: loyal customers order for family abroad — Carvi Food designed for this with gift-ready packaging

C — Information Architecture and Product Communication

When you are the first in a category, consumer education is part of the UX. Carvi Food had to answer questions that no competitor had ever addressed:

- 'Is this safe?' — Addressed through visible hygiene standards, packaging, and production story
- 'How long does it last?' — Shelf life clearly communicated on every package and in WhatsApp conversations
- 'How do I eat it?' — Serving suggestions and pairing ideas shared as part of the brand voice
- 'Can I trust it?' — Built over 9 years of consistent quality and direct customer relationships

D — The WhatsApp as CRM (Customer Relationship Management)

An unexpected UX outcome: WhatsApp became Carvi Food's most powerful customer relationship tool. Because every order goes through a direct conversation:

WhatsApp as UX Tool	UX Benefit
Order confirmation	Customer feels heard, not processed
Delivery updates	No anxiety about 'where is my order?'
Customer feedback collection	Real-time qualitative data — no survey needed
Product announcements	Direct channel with zero algorithm interference
Personalized re-engagement	'We haven't seen you in a while' — human touch
Gifting coordination	High-value seasonal revenue with minimal friction

E — UX Metrics: What 'Success' Looks Like at Carvi Food

9 yrs Brand longevity — trust is the ultimate UX metric	80%+ Customer retention rate (repeat buyers)	#1 Category position in the Senegalese dried meat market
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Reflections: What Carvi Food Taught Me About UX

Insight 1 — Design for the real user, not the ideal user

80% of my customers prefer WhatsApp to a web form. A good UX designer builds for that reality, not for a hypothetical tech-savvy user who enjoys checkout forms. Meeting users where they are is not a shortcut — it is the work.

Insight 2 — First-mover brands must design the category, not just the product

When no competitor exists, your product IS the consumer's mental model of the entire category. Every packaging, pricing, and communication decision shapes what 'quality dried meat' means in Senegal. That is a design responsibility.

Insight 3 — Retention is the most honest UX metric

Anyone can get a first sale. Getting the same customer back for 9 years — that is the result of a product experience that consistently delivers what it promises. Retention does not lie.